

Digital Literacy

ARFD106

CLIENT

Montclair State University

YEAR

2019–2024

Digital Literacy (ARFD106) was a three-credit foundation course for undergraduate art and design students at Montclair State University, offered asynchronously. I developed and taught it from 2019, with the Spring 2024 iteration representing the most fully realized version of the design. The course addressed a gap in art education: students who had grown up as sophisticated users of digital tools but had limited understanding of how those tools worked, what choices they encoded, or what it meant to make with them rather than through them.

The course ran on two simultaneous tracks. One was a tool sequence: Photoshop, then Illustrator, then InDesign, then After Effects. The other was a thematic sequence: counterfactual history, then the attention economy, then race and technology, then cumulative synthesis. Each creative project landed immediately after the tools it required, so students applied techniques before they had time to forget them, and the thematic brief gave them a reason to care about what the tools could do.

Delivering this as an asynchronous course created specific design constraints. Without scheduled class time, the structures that normally hold studio work together had to be built into the course itself: the live critique, the shared workspace, the visible presence of what others are making.

The Architecture

The tool and thematic tracks are designed to reinforce each other rather than run independently. Photoshop instruction covers selections, masking, and compositing: the technical vocabulary for making a convincing photographic composite. Creative Project 1 introduces Alexander Malchenko, a Soviet engineer erased from historical photographs on Lenin's orders in 1929, and asks students to make their own photographic fiction. The assignment is not a Photoshop exercise with a creative theme attached. The historical problem is the brief; Photoshop is what makes it possible.

The same logic governs the middle of the course. Illustrator instruction covers vector drawing, shape construction, and compositional thinking. The mid-semester project is framed by a substantive reading that moves from Herbert Simon's 1971 observation about the poverty of attention through Richard Serra's "Television Delivers People," surveillance capitalism, and hyperpersonalization. Students produce an image that engages with those ideas using the tools they have just learned. InDesign follows, covering type, layout, and image integration, feeding directly into Creative Project 2: Race and Technology, which asks students to bring research and design together in a single piece and use the project as an occasion to push further into whichever tools interest them most.

After Effects arrives at the end of the course, and the final project is not a new brief. It is a Redux: students return to a previous project and rethink it through the introduction of time. The brief names this directly: "redux means to bring back, or happen again; the creative process is always a redux." After Effects is positioned not as the final item in a tool sequence but as a reason to go back and see more in existing work. The course ends with students deepening ideas they have spent the whole semester developing, rather than beginning something new.

The Mid-Semester

The mid-semester project is where the asynchronous constraints were most directly addressed. It runs across five items in the module: an introduction page, a first-iteration submission, a discussion board, a required one-on-one Zoom critique with the professor, and a second-iteration submission. The critique is required before the second submission can be submitted, functioning as a gate rather than an optional check-in. It is a synchronous point of contact built deliberately into an otherwise asynchronous structure: a place where the conversation about the work happens in real time, and where the feedback that drives revision is generated.

The V1 and V2 rubrics are different from each other by design. The V1 rubric assesses research, creative application, and craft. The V2 rubric replaces the research criterion with a new first criterion: integration of feedback and development of the work. The change makes the purpose of iteration explicit and gradeable. It tells students what they are being assessed on before they revise, rather than leaving them to infer that revision is expected and to guess what excellent revision looks like.

The discussion prompt for the mid-semester post is the most carefully written piece of student-facing text in the course. It asks students to write about how they got to the image, what they think works, and what does not. The peer response guidance is specific: "Be brave: criticizing a strong work without saying it is good is as dishonest as not telling someone that the work isn't there yet when it isn't." Students are told to find connections for the person they are responding to, to introduce them to films, images, books, articles, and music. This positions peer review as an act of companionship rather than evaluation, which is the register a studio course requires and which most asynchronous discussion boards do not attempt.

Assessment Design

Each creative project is assessed on three criteria: thematic engagement, creative application, and craft. The balance shifts between projects to reflect what each one emphasizes. CP1 weights Photoshop skill highest, at 40 of 100 points, reflecting that it is the first project and technical competence is being established alongside the creative work. By CP2, thematic integration and creative application dominate, reflecting that students are now expected to bring the conceptual material into the work, not just demonstrate tool knowledge.

The rubric language throughout is descriptive rather than procedural. "Excellent craft" is described as showing solid understanding of the software and demonstrating good visual fundamentals in drawing and composition. "Lackluster project" is described as showing visual clichés, a lack of visual development, or a confusing impact. The language asks for a judgment about the work rather than a checklist of required elements, consistent with how studio work is normally assessed and with the kind of conversation the course is trying to generate.

The CP1 discussion prompt includes one specifically well-designed instruction: students are told to highlight what is happening in the image by pointing out what is there, not what is not there. Students making composited counterfactual images are prone to explaining what they removed from history rather than what they constructed. The redirect is small but consequential: it trains attention toward what is actually visible in the work, which is also what is assessable and what is discussable by peers.

Reflection

The course's central wager is that tools and ideas are more interesting together than separately, and that introducing a Photoshop technique in the context of a genuine historical and conceptual problem is more motivating and more memorable than introducing it as a neutral technical competency. The brief writing in the course supports this: the Malchenko introduction narrates the historical case before it names the assignment; the attention economy reading is substantive enough to generate real positions before students open Illustrator; the artist reference lists in each brief are curated toward the specific conceptual territory of that project.

The most significant design gap is in the CP1 rubric. It assesses imaginative creation and visual craft but has no criterion for engagement with the historical material. A student who produces a technically convincing image from a muddled or uninvestigated premise is not differentiated from one who has done the research. Given how much intellectual scaffolding the brief provides, a criterion for conceptual engagement would bring the assessment into alignment with the assignment's actual demands, and would signal earlier in the course that the ideas are as assessable as the making.
